Delivering the Gospel

Paul is not writing autobiography; he is defending his ministry — and in doing so paints a master class in delivering the gospel faithfully. Are you carrying the gospel, or getting in its way?

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Where this study fits

1 Thessalonians · ten studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 **An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church**	**02** 1:6–10 **The Many Faces of the Gospel**	**03** 2:1–12 **Delivering the Gospel**	**04** 2:13–20 **A Successful Life of Service**	**05** 3:1–13 **Facing Tribulation**
06 4:1–12 **A Life That Pleases God**	**07** 4:13–18 **The Rapture of the Church**	**08** 5:1–11 **The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope**	**09** 5:12–22 **The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations**	**10** 5:23–28 **'Til We Meet Again**

"Finally" (4:1) marks the hinge: chapters 1–3 lay the foundation; chapters 4–5 turn that theology into life.

Delivering the gospel, verse by verse

1 Thessalonians 2:1–12 · Outline I–II

v.1	His coming — not in vain	**κενός** empty — a wasted trip
v.2	His circumstance — beaten at Philippi, bold at Thessalonica	**παρρησιάζομαι** spoke boldly, in the open
vv.3–4	His assertions — no error, uncleanness or deceit; approved and entrusted	**δοκιμάζω · πιστεύω** tested · entrusted
vv.5–6	What he refused — guile, gain and glory	**—** God is witness
vv.7–9	What he revealed and reserved — a mother's love; working night and day	**τροφός** nursing mother
v.10	His attitude — devoutly, justly, blamelessly	**ὁσίως · δικαίως · ἀμέμπτως** a life that matched the message
vv.11–12	His apprehensions — a father's charge: walk worthy of God	**ἀξίως** of equal weight — a balance scale

Where success and failure belong

1 Thessalonians 2:1 · I.A — Paul’s coming

Success belongs to God

- Any fruit is God’s doing — He gets the credit
- The gospel carries its own power
- The messenger cannot manufacture conversion

vs

Failure belongs to man

- To the messenger — if he failed in content or conviction
- To the hearers — if they failed in faith or follow-up
- Not to a faithful messenger whose hearers refuse

“If I go out and witness to ten people and nine reject it, I was not a failure nine times. If I presented the gospel faithfully and didn’t get in God’s way, I am not a failure at all.”

Three ways to corrupt the message

1 Thessalonians 2:3 · II.A.1a — The truth shown

Not from error
πλάνη planē · G4106

Content
- Not a drifting, untethered teaching
- Checked against Scripture — and found true
- The gospel is verifiable

Nor uncleanness
ἀκαθαρσία akatharsia · G167

Conduct
- Pagan worship was saturated with immorality
- Paul's ministry had none of it
- The gospel is pure

Nor deceit
δόλος dolos · G1388

Method
- No traps, no bait
- Nothing hidden behind an attractive presentation
- No misleading promises

Content, character, method — a messenger can corrupt the gospel at any of the three.

What the gospel promises — and what it doesn’t

1 Thessalonians 2:3 · Free from deceit (misleading promises)

× Off the table

- “You will be more prosperous.” — you might get fired
- “You will be happier.” — some lives got harder
- “Your marriage will be better.” — some spouses left

vs

✓ What Paul offered

- You will have eternal life
- Your sins will be forgiven
- A personal relationship with the God of the universe
- A home in heaven — a place prepared for you

Don’t make promises the gospel doesn’t make. Don’t withhold the promises it does make.

Approved, entrusted — so we speak

1 Thessalonians 2:4 · II.A.1b–2 — The truth spoken

A

Tested

Assayed in the fire and found genuine

δοκιμάζω

B

Entrusted

Paul trusted God; God trusted Paul with the gospel

πιστεύω — same verb

C

Spoken

“Even so we speak” — three words

2 Cor 5:20 — ambassadors

D

Undisturbed

Not pleasing men, but God who tests our hearts

v.4c

God has believed in you enough to put His gospel in your hands. The Great Commission is not a clergy assignment; it is a whole-church commission.

What Paul refused, revealed and reserved

1 Thessalonians 2:5–9 · II.B — Paul's actions

A — No guile · v.5a

Flattery to manipulate implies the gospel isn't good enough

B — No gain · v.5b

No cloak for covetousness — "God is witness"

C — No glory · v.6

He had an apostle's rights — and chose not to use them

D — A mother's love · v.7

τροφός — a nursing mother gives of her own substance

E — His own life · v.8

Not a hands-on job but an arms-around job

F — Night and day · v.9

He worked so as not to burden them — no one could say he preached for profit

A mother and a father

1 Thessalonians 2:7–12 · II.B.2 and II.D — Two pictures of ministry

A nursing mother · vv.7–8
τροφός trophos · G5162

- Holds, feeds, warms
- Gives of her own substance
- Imparts the gospel and her own life

Before two witnesses · v.10

- Devoutly — ὁσίως
- Justly — δικαίως
- Blamelessly — ἀμέμπτως
- “You are witnesses, and God also”

A father · vv.11–12
παρακαλοῦντες exhorting · G3870

- Exhorted — called alongside
- Comforted — arm around the shoulder
- Charged — testified (μαρτυρόμενοι)

The goal · v.12: “that you would walk worthy (ἀξίως) of God who calls you” — a life that carries the same weight as the calling.

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 2:1–12 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Paul denies three things in verse 3 — error, uncleanness and deceit. What specific danger does each one represent for a gospel messenger today?

2. Paul uses a nursing mother (v.7) and a father (v.11). What is distinctive about each image, and what would a ministry shaped by both look like in your group?

Apply

Refuse the Three G's
Find one place this week where you'd seek recognition for a spiritual contribution — and deliberately step back.

Impart Not Just the Gospel, But Your Life
Schedule one meal, coffee or visit this month with someone who isn't yet a believer — simply to be present.

In one line: Carry the gospel — don't dilute it, don't exploit it, don't perform it. Just deliver it, and don't get in God's way.